How to Write About Your Art

Part 2: The Artist Statement

ARTIST COMMONS

“An intellectual says a simple thing in a hard way.
An artist says a hard thing in a simple way.”

– Charles Bukowski

“Tell the truth and not the facts.”

– Maya Angelou

Warm-Up Exercise

Sense Description

- From your five senses, pick one sense.
  - ➢ Taste, Touch, Smell, Hearing, Sight.
- Describe the room you're in with obsessive attention to only this one sense.

The Three Questions to Ask

1. What is it?
What does it look like? How is it made? What happened?

2. What might this mean?
How does the form or event carry meaning?

3. Why does this matter to the world at large?
What does it contribute to the world? Or, so what?

From Gilda Williams's *How to Write About Contemporary Art* (2014)

2. What might this mean?

- What is this work about for you?
- How does this object, as a form or event, carry meaning?
- Young artists make images. Mature artists make meaning.
- Find your thesis statement. Have a theory about your art.
- Make your answers specific to you.

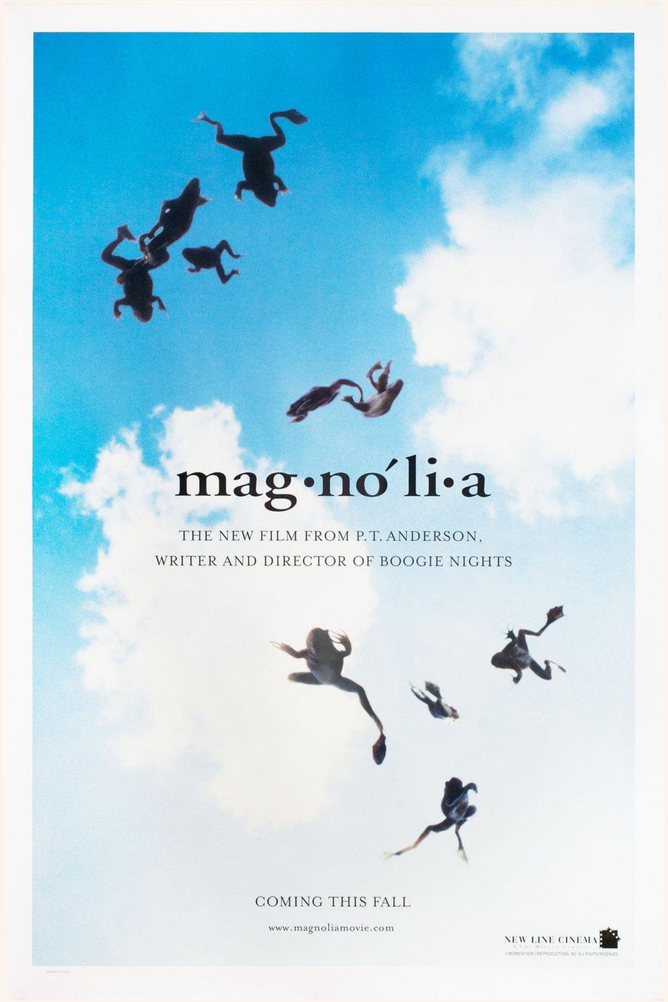
“Come up with your own theory. People who claim to hate or have no theory: That’s your theory, you idiots!”

– Jerry Saltz

How to Be An Artist (2020)

What does this mean?

Broad Themes & Scaffolding Viewing





Your job is to help a viewer go deeper with your work

“Never use a metaphor, simile or other figure of speech which you are used to seeing in print.”

– George Orwell

Phrases to Avoid

- “The work explores themes of…”
- “The artist investigates the relationship between…”
- “The piece interrogates notions of…”
- “The work challenges traditional ideas of…”
- “The artist creates a dialogue between…”
- “The viewer is invited to…”
- “The piece blurs the boundary between…”
- “The work exists in a liminal space between…”
- “The work speaks to broader questions of…”

Verbs to avoid

- Explores
- Investigates
- Interrogates
- Reconceptualizes
- Deconstructs
- Symbolizes
- Unpacks

Words to avoid

- Liminal
- Immersive
- Urgent
- Relational
- Mystical
- Nuanced
- Provocative

Exercise #3

8 Questions on Meaning

1. What is this piece about to me?
2. What inspired this work, or set its creation in motion?
3. Are there references you hope the viewer picks up on?
4. What are the broad themes of this piece or series?

“I don’t write out of what I know; I write out of what I wonder. I think most artists create art in order to explore, not to give the answers. Poetry and art are not about answers to me; they are about questions.”

– Lucille Clifton

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2. What inspired this work, or set its creation in motion?
3. Are there references you hope the viewer picks up on?
4. What are the broad themes of this piece or series?
5. What is the work trying to express or communicate?
6. What question(s) is this piece trying to answer?
7. How does it dialogue with other artworks or the history of the medium?
8. What’s the one thing you want people to walk away with, or remember about the work?

“The skill of writing is to create a context in which other people can think.”

– Edwin Schlossberg

“Make visible what, without you, might perhaps never have been seen.”

– Robert Bresson

3. Why does this matter to the world at large?

- What does this work contribute to the world?
- Or, to put it bluntly: So what?
- What makes the work memorable?
- Why is the work worthy of slowing down and giving it attention in this busy world?

Exercise #4

Write a Letter to a Friend telling them:

- Why this artwork is important to you.
- Why it feels like a breakthrough.
- How it pushes the arc of your work forward.
- What was different this time about your approach.
- What makes this piece feel unique compared to the work of other artists in your medium or genre.

7 Things to Avoid

1. Not having a thesis.
2. Telling the viewer what they will feel or think.
3. My work explores _____ & _____.
4. International Art English.
5. Talking only to fellow insiders.
6. Grandiose declarations.
7. Don’t quote from or compare yourself to the greats.

Your Homework

- Put what you just wrote in a drawer.
- Next week, pull it out and mark the good bits:
  - Underline the strong sentences
  - Circle the strong phrases
  - Box the strong words
- Copy those into a Word document.
- Rearrange those fragments into paragraphs.
- Play with the order.
- Then write the connective tissue.

“Every first draft is perfect because all the first draft has to do is exist.”

– Jane Smiley

“Words are sacred. They deserve respect. If you get the right ones, in the right order, you can nudge the world a little.”

– Tom Stoppard